

The Emergency Brake

For when breathing is out of reach. Build your kit while you're settled.

Counted breathing asks for two things a flooded body doesn't have: a thinking brain, and comfortable attention on your own insides. When the wave is that big, go outside-in instead. None of these need counting, and none need your eyes closed. Check the ones your body says yes to, then build your kit below, today, while you're calm. Nobody chooses tools mid-wave.

- ☐ **Cold.** Cold water on your face, an ice cube in your fist, something cold on the back of your neck. The body slows the heart on its own; it doesn't ask the mind first.
- ☐ **Eyes before breath.** Turn your head. Track the room. Name five things you can see, out loud.
- ☐ **Let the body move.** Push hard against a wall. Squeeze your fists and let go. Shake, stomp, walk fast. A revved body is loaded for motion; give it some.
- ☐ **One strong sensation.** Sour candy. A strong mint. Something rough in your hand.
- ☐ **Sound instead of counting.** One long, low hum. The hum stretches the exhale without anything that feels like an exercise.
- ☐ **Another nervous system.** A voice you trust. A pet under your hand. Borrowed calm is real calm.

MY INTERRUPT KIT

My cold thing: _____

My five-things place to look: _____

My movement: _____

My strong sensation (kept where?): _____

My sound: _____

My person (or pet): _____

Match the tool to the state: a revved body wants cold and motion. A shut-down body wants gentle looking around, warmth, and small movement. And if you used the brake this week, that was not a setback. That was the practice, working.

This worksheet is education and practice, not therapy, diagnosis, or medical treatment, and it is not a substitute for care from a licensed mental-health or medical professional. If you are in crisis: call or text 988 (US) · text HOME to 741741 · SAMHSA 1-800-662-4357 · if in immediate danger, call 911.